



Run spree: Shubman Gill's series aggregate of 754 was the second-highest tally of a captain, only behind Don Bradman's 810 in 1936. GETTY IMAGES

Touring England is never easy. India has not won a Test series there since 2007, but from the outset, this team resolved not to dwell on the past. Gambhir was clear: this side would write its own history. Coming off two series defeats — at home to New Zealand and away to Australia — the pressure was mounting, yet the players rose to the occasion.

In the first two matches, openers Yashasvi Jaiswal and Rahul gave India steady starts. Their centuries on flat decks shielded Gill from the new ball, allowing the middle order to play freely. Rahul made full use of his experience, Jaiswal was flamboyant, and Gill avoided facing the first 20

overs in his first five innings. That helped him play naturally on untroubled surfaces. Even though he struggled against the incoming ball in the last three Tests, he spent hours in the nets with batting coach Sitanshu Kotak to address the flaw. The results were immediate as he went on to score a vital hundred in India's second innings in Manchester to help eke out a series-saving draw.

"He is a quality player, and when you start your captaincy stint, that extra responsibility really helps your batting in the early stages. Maybe, towards the back end, it becomes more difficult. But right at the moment, he's in that sweet spot, and

I suppose he's just got to ride the wave and enjoy it," former England captain Andrew Strauss told *Sportstar*.

As Gill's confidence grew, he backed his players strongly. Senior campaigners like Ravindra Jadeja and Rahul also stepped in with key inputs. At The Oval, when Joe Root and Harry Brook built a threatening partnership, Jadeja advised Gill, "*Idhar se dalwa, idhar se...*", suggesting a change of ends for Krishna and Akash. The switch worked, with Krishna striking from the Micky Stewart Pavilion end to remove Root. England would eventually slip from 337 for six to be